

Repentance



A U-turn sign beside a road that was heading the other way. Repentance is not feeling bad in the same lane. The sign is an instruction to turn around.

Before you gather

- Read Day 26, Repentance, in The Visual Gospel. Do not reteach the essay.
- Read Luke 19:1–10 in your Bible. The excerpt below is only a backup.
- Your people should already have answered the day's reflection questions. Do not ask those again.

- Leave with a name. The missional challenge only works if someone is named before you pray.

1 · ICEBREAKER · 7 MIN

Open the room

When did a wrong turn cost you real time, and how long did you argue with the map before you turned around?

Leader. Delay and pride. The book already asked about godly sorrow and about easy believism. Do not rerun those two questions. Say that passing is allowed, especially the first few weeks.

2 · THE WORD · 8 MIN

See it, then say it

IF YOU NEED THE WORDS

Say: Jesus' first sermon puts two words together: repent and believe. Repentance is a real turn of mind, heart, and life, joined to faith in the gospel. It is not "be nicer." Tears in the same lane are not a U-turn.

DEFINITION, FROM THE BOOK

Repentance is the turning of a sinner away from sin and toward God, involving a change of mind, heart, and direction of life.

IN THE ORIGINAL LANGUAGE

Greek metanoia — a change of mind that turns the whole person.

MEMORY VERSE · MARK 1:15

The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.

Together, open the flashcard for Repentance. Say the word, the definition, and the verse once. Then put the phone away.

3 · OPEN THE BIBLE · 15 MIN

Luke 19:1–10

Zacchaeus turns in public, and in his money, the same day Jesus welcomes him. You can see the U-turn. You are not opening a confession circle. Jesus seeks. The sinner turns.

He entered Jericho and was passing through. And behold, there was a man named Zacchaeus. He was a chief tax collector and rich. ... And when Jesus came to the place, he looked up and said to him, "Zacchaeus, hurry and come down, for I must stay at your house today." ... And Zacchaeus stood and said to the Lord, "Behold, Lord, the half of my goods I give to the poor. And if I have defrauded anyone of anything, I restore it fourfold." And Jesus said to him, "Today salvation has come to this house... For the Son of Man came to seek and to save the lost."

Have two readers if you can. Bibles open. The excerpt is only here so a forgotten Bible does not stop the night.

From the passage

1. Who moves first: Zacchaeus climbing, or Jesus calling? What does Zacchaeus do after Jesus comes to the house? **CORE**

Leader. Jesus seeks and calls. Zacchaeus answers with joy and a costly turn: he gives, and he pays back what he stole. Repentance responds to the Seeker. It does not earn the visit. It is not a self-help project.

2. Jesus calls this salvation, and He calls Zacchaeus lost in the same breath, though he is a son of Abraham. Lost from what, if he was already near Israel's religion?

Leader. Lost is not only "far from church." A wealthy insider can be lost. Salvation comes to the house. The issue was not manners. It was direction, and it was Christ.

4 · AROUND THE ROOM · 20 MIN

A conversation this chapter did not assign

3. Mark 1:15 will not split repent from believe. What does a so-called faith look like with no U-turn, and what does a turn look like with no gospel to turn toward? **CORE**

Leader. Faith with no turn is an empty claim. A turn with no gospel is moralism, or despair. “Be nicer” is neither repentance nor faith. Jesus holds the two together.

4. Acts 3:19: repent and turn, that sins may be blotted out. Acts 26:20: deeds in keeping with repentance. Why is paying people back, when you can, part of the turn, and not a way of paying Jesus back?

Leader. Zacchaeus does not purchase salvation. The welcome came first. The money shows the turn is real. Jesus was our substitute. Where payback is impossible, the turn still shows: confess the sin, and change direction.

5. You do not have to name a sin out loud in this circle. What is the shape of a real turn, a change of direction and not only a regret, that you already know?

Leader. Shape, not a performance: a habit stopped, a person repaid, a lie corrected, a relationship met differently. Do not go around the circle demanding stories. A quiet room is not the method. The method is the Word: repent and believe the gospel.

5 · SAY IT · 5 MIN

In one sentence

Repentance is a real turn of mind, heart, and life away from sin and toward God, joined to faith in the gospel.

Ask for two volunteers, not the whole circle. They may look at the sentence, then try it without looking. Clumsy and true is the goal.

6 · THIS WEEK · 5 MIN

Missional challenge

Before next week, carry this word to someone far from Jesus — a neighbor, a classmate, a coworker, a friend. Do it with a real action and with a true sentence. Name the person before you pray.

Turn from one pattern someone far from Jesus has watched in you. Tell them you are turning because of Christ. Say repentance is a real change

of mind, heart, and life, joined to faith in Him, not “be nicer.”

Leader. Help them name the pattern before they leave. “Be nicer” is not a turn. The sentence must join the turn to Jesus. Next week, before the icebreaker, take one minute. Who went, and what happened? One sentence. No speeches.

7 · PRAY · 8 MIN

Pray these, and leave room for others

1. Thank Jesus that He seeks the lost and does not wait to be impressed.
2. Ask for a real turn where you have only felt sorry and stayed in the same lane.
3. Pray for a house, like Zacchaeus’s, where salvation still needs to arrive through the gospel.

Before you stumble

Do not turn the group into a confession booth, and do not embarrass anyone. If someone confesses something serious, receive it briefly, thank them, and take the rest offline with care. Repentance is not penance. You do not assign spiritual punishments. It is also not nothing. Easy agreement with no new direction is not Mark 1:15. Hold both, without a debate-club tone. The call is simple: turn, and trust Christ.

WITH STUDENTS

Ask what a U-turn looks like on a phone: who they stop texting, what they stop watching, who they tell the truth to. Specific beats a mood. “Be nicer” is not repentance.

IF YOU STILL HAVE TIME

2 Corinthians 7:8–10, only if someone asks whether sorrow counts. Godly grief produces a turn. Worldly grief is regret with no change of road. They may have read this in the book. Use it to clarify, not as the main text.